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Don Bradman. Garry Sobers. Sunil Gavaskar. Sachin Tendulkar. Viv Richards. These players left a huge imprint on the game in their era. Their exits evoked heartfelt tributes from fans and media alike. Virat Kohli has joined that list by stepping away from Test cricket — a format that meant the world to him.

For us in Delhi, following the journeys of Virender Sehwag and Virat meant years of focused attention on their rise from the junior circuit to the international stage. Interestingly, both Sehwag and Virat were initially rejected by Delhi's talent spotters and junior selectors. But they forced a rethink by piling on runs and embarrassing the decision-makers at Ferozeshah Kotla (now Arun Jaitley Stadium).

While working on Virat's biography, I discovered a deep and widespread admiration for his dedication to the game. His contribution to Delhi cricket was acknowledged across the board. Coaches and colleagues spoke in awe of his ability to adapt and deliver. You couldn't keep him away from cricket. If given a choice, he'd have played 24 hours a day.

I always found him in a different zone when he stepped onto the field. Restless after a stint in the nets, he would quickly shift to fielding drills or bowl to teammates. His energy lifted everyone around him.

Like Tendulkar, watching him bat at the nets was a joy. He constantly experimented with his shots, especially against fast bowlers. It

was routine to see him ask bowlers to send down bouncers from 18 yards. That was his way of preparing for international challenges.

His ability to handle pace impressed coaches and teammates alike. That skill was honed through long hours at the nets. He hated missing domestic games, convinced that they sharpened his edge. He relished tricky pitches because they tested his survival skills.

What I admired most was his eagerness to talk cricket. After returning from tours, he'd often join his Delhi teammates if they were playing at the Kotla. His presence on the dressing-room balcony had an immediate effect — the energy levels rose, and the desire to compete became visible.

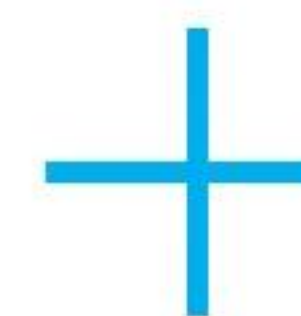
That competitive streak came from the hard-nosed culture of Delhi cricket, where a youngster had to fight for space. Virat mastered that fight. He wasn't content playing only in his age group. He constantly pushed to move up the ranks. His coaches had to protect him from burning out, but he was obsessed with batting early and taking on senior bowlers.

He was happiest among cricketers. At his wedding reception in Delhi, he made sure to invite all his coaches and colleagues from junior cricket. He often helped juniors by observing their game and offering advice. He had no patience for laziness and wouldn't hesitate to let someone know, but he always followed it up with a quiet chat to make the player feel valued. He had the rare grace to apologise when he crossed a line.

Delhi cricket changed significantly because of Virat's success at the international level. I remember hearing stories of a young boy from West Delhi taking on senior bowlers in local matches, fearlessly. Reputation didn't faze him. He took the fight to the opposition — brave, even cocky, but always memorable.

There were strong echoes of Sehwag in him. Both backed themselves without hesitation. Sehwag was a big influence. When he sensed Virat was losing focus, he sent quiet reminders. Virat responded instantly and never gave Sehwag a reason to be disappointed again.

He was a natural motivator.



One incident still stands out. A young girl battling a serious illness wanted a video message from Virat. A friend connected her with me. When I asked Virat, he immediately recorded a heartfelt message.